

financier families, like the Bischoffsheims, Pereires, the Seligmans, and the Lazards. . . .

While positive aspects of the family identity need to be nurtured, negative features need to be suppressed. Alcoholism or suicide might be in the family history or DNA, but, certainly, you'd want to push those out of the family brand. That doesn't mean that you sweep the issues under the rug. You have to deal with them. But you counter them with positive messages and a positive example.

The Kennedy family fortune was made partially from stock manipulation, insider trading, and bootlegging. But they managed to successfully brand the family into a political force that would ascend to the U.S. presidency and various other high-level positions within the government.

The Bush family also managed to parlay its family identity into a political dynasty.

In each of these cases, each generation is able to build on the successes of the previous generation. Again, we don't approve of either of these family examples. As Monsieur Mulliez explained, you want to avoid publicity. You should avoid talking to the press. And you should avoid the lure of becoming insiders. But at least these examples show how powerful family branding can be.

Keep in mind that all your family members have identities of their own. They will react negatively if you try to impose a brand, or an identity, that they don't like. You can't do these things by force. Instead, you have to lead by example and exert a positive, nurturing influence. You can help them see things from (your) family perspective. A family identity must be a vision of the future that family members share. And it has to be farsighted. It has to be fixed, like the North Star—something that will guide generations. But it must also be flexible enough to take on changes from the next generation.

In forming the family identity, think about what you want to be in 20, 50, or 100 years. You'll need your family members on board with everything. You'll need your vision of the future to match with theirs.